CarnivoreCalc: The Complete 30-Day Carnivore Meal Plan

Your Practical, No-BS Guide to Starting the Carnivore Diet

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Table of Contents

1. Introduction: What Is Carnivore & Why It Works
2. The Adaptation Phase: Days 1–7
3. Complete 30-Day Meal Plan
4. Weekly Shopping Lists
5. Macro Tracking Guide
6. Budget Carnivore vs. Premium
7. Eating Out Guide
8. Electrolytes & Supplements
9. Top 10 Beginner Mistakes
10. FAQ: Top 20 Questions

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1. Introduction: What Is Carnivore & Why It Works {#introduction}

What Is the Carnivore Diet?

The carnivore diet is exactly what it sounds like: you eat only animal products. Meat, fish, eggs, and animal fats. Nothing else. No vegetables, no fruit, no grains, no legumes, no seed oils. Just animals.

This isn't a fad diet cooked up by a wellness influencer. It's arguably the most ancestral diet humans have ever eaten, and the clinical results people are seeing — dramatic weight loss, reduced inflammation, improved mental clarity, and resolved autoimmune conditions — are hard to ignore.

Why It Works

1. Eliminates plant toxins. Plants can't run away from predators, so they've evolved chemical defenses — oxalates, lectins, phytates, and other compounds that can damage the gut lining, interfere with nutrient absorption, and trigger immune responses. Remove plants, and many people find chronic inflammation simply goes away.

2. Naturally regulates appetite. Protein and fat are the two most satiating macronutrients. When you eat mostly protein and fat, you stop being hungry all the time. No more 3pm crashes. No more counting calories.

3. Stabilizes blood sugar. Carbohydrates spike blood glucose. Meat doesn't. On carnivore, your blood sugar runs stable and low all day. This is why diabetics and pre-diabetics often see their numbers normalize rapidly.

4. Simplicity. There's no app needed, no label reading, no worrying about which oil to cook in. If it had a mother or laid an egg, you can eat it.

5. Nutrient density. Beef liver is the most nutrient-dense food on the planet — nothing in the plant kingdom comes close. Red meat provides complete protein with every essential amino acid, bioavailable iron, zinc, B12, creatine, and carnosine in forms your body can actually absorb.

What to Expect in the First 30 Days

Week 1 (Days 1–7): Adaptation. Your body switches fuel systems — from glucose to fat. This can be rough. You may feel tired, foggy, irritable, and have carb cravings. This is normal and temporary. Push through.

Week 2 (Days 8–14): Clearing. Energy starts to stabilize. Bloating goes down. Sleep often improves. Cravings begin to fade.

Week 3 (Days 15–21): Adaptation complete. Mental clarity kicks in. You're not hungry between meals. You feel lighter. People start noticing.

Week 4 (Days 22–30): You're a carnivore. Energy is stable, cravings are gone, and you have a new baseline for how good you can feel. Most people want to keep going.

The Rules (Simple Version)

- ✅ **Eat:** Beef, pork, lamb, chicken, turkey, fish, seafood, eggs, butter, ghee, tallow, lard, hard cheese (optional), heavy cream (optional)
- ❌ **Don't eat:** Everything else — vegetables, fruit, grains, legumes, nuts, seeds, sugar, seed oils, alcohol
- 🧂 **Salt your food:** This is critical. You will lose electrolytes rapidly when you cut carbs.
- 💧 **Drink water:** Thirst is your guide. Drink when thirsty.
- 🍽️ **Eat when hungry, stop when full:** No calorie counting required.

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2. The Adaptation Phase: Days 1–7 {#adaptation-phase}

What's Happening in Your Body

When you cut carbohydrates, your body depletes its glycogen (stored glucose) reserves. This happens within 24–72 hours. As glycogen drops, so does water weight — glycogen is stored with water, and you'll release 3–8 pounds of water in the first week. This is good, but it also means you're flushing electrolytes.

At the same time, your metabolism is being reprogrammed. Your cells are learning to run on fat and ketones instead of glucose. This transition has a cost: the infamous **adaptation phase**.

What You'll Feel

Days 1–2: You feel fine. Maybe even great. The glycogen is still there.

Days 2–4: The Wall. This is where most people quit. You may experience:

- Fatigue and low energy (your cells are switching fuel types)
- Brain fog and difficulty concentrating
- Headache
- Muscle cramps or weakness (electrolyte loss)
- Irritability
- Strong carb cravings (your gut bacteria are dying off and screaming for sugar)
- Diarrhea or loose stools (your gut is adjusting)

Days 5–7: The fog starts to lift. Energy starts to return. Cravings soften.

How to Push Through

1. Eat more fat. If you're struggling, eat more. More butter, more fatty beef, more bacon. You're not trying to create a calorie deficit right now — you're teaching your body to burn fat.

2. Salt aggressively. Add salt to everything. Drink a glass of salted water in the morning. This is not optional during adaptation. Electrolyte loss is the #1 cause of adaptation symptoms.

3. Eat enough protein. Don't be afraid of the protein. Aim for at least 1g per pound of lean body mass. Under-eating protein leads to fatigue and muscle loss.

4. Don't cheat. Every carb you eat resets the adaptation process and extends your suffering. One cheat meal can set you back 3 days. The fastest path through adaptation is straight through.

5. Rest. This is not the time to run a marathon. Reduce intense exercise to easy walks for the first 5–7 days.

6. Take magnesium. 300–400mg of magnesium glycinate before bed helps with cramps, sleep, and general adaptation symptoms.

7. Drink bone broth. A warm mug of salted bone broth is the carnivore answer to Gatorade. It replaces electrolytes and soothes the gut.

The Mindset

The adaptation phase is like the first week of any hard thing — quitting smoking, starting a new job, learning to swim. It's hard precisely because you're changing. When it gets uncomfortable, remember: **this is what changing feels like**. The discomfort is temporary. What's on the other side is worth it.

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3. Complete 30-Day Meal Plan {#30-day-meal-plan}

How to Use This Plan

- **Portions are approximate.** Listen to your hunger. Eat until satisfied, not stuffed.
- **"Fatty" beef** = ribeye, chuck, 80/20 ground beef, short ribs
- **Lean beef** = sirloin, 90/10 ground beef, flank steak
- All cooking is in butter, ghee, tallow, or lard. No seed oils.
- Water and plain sparkling water are your only beverages. Black coffee is okay for most people.
- If a meal doesn't appeal, swap it for a similar meal from another day — the plan is a template, not a prison.

Week 1: Adaptation

Day 1 — Monday

- 🍳 **Breakfast:** 4 eggs scrambled in 2 tbsp butter + 4 strips bacon
- 🥩 **Lunch:** 8oz 80/20 ground beef patties (2 burgers, no bun) cooked in tallow
- 🥩 **Dinner:** 12oz ribeye steak, pan-seared in butter + salt

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Day 2 — Tuesday

- 🍳 **Breakfast:** 3-egg omelette with 2oz shredded cheddar + 4 strips bacon
- 🥩 **Lunch:** 6oz canned wild salmon mixed with butter, served warm
- 🥩 **Dinner:** 10oz pork shoulder chops, cooked in lard + salt

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Day 3 — Wednesday

- 🍳 **Breakfast:** 4 eggs fried in butter + 2 pork sausage links (check label: no fillers)
- 🥩 **Lunch:** 8oz 80/20 ground beef, pan-fried, seasoned with salt

- 🥩 **Dinner:** 10oz chicken thighs (skin on), roasted in butter + salt

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Day 4 — Thursday *(Adaptation hits hardest today — salt up)*

- 🍳 **Breakfast:** 4 scrambled eggs + 6 strips bacon + 1 tbsp butter in eggs
- 🥩 **Lunch:** 8oz ground beef + 1 cup bone broth (drink it)
- 🥩 **Dinner:** 12oz NY strip steak + 2 tbsp butter melted on top

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Day 5 — Friday

- 🍳 **Breakfast:** 4 eggs any style + 4 strips bacon + black coffee (optional)
- 🥩 **Lunch:** 8oz ground beef patties
- 🥩 **Dinner:** 10oz salmon fillet, pan-seared in butter

Day 6 — Saturday

- 🍳 **Breakfast:** Steak & eggs — 6oz sirloin + 3 eggs, pan-fried in butter
- 🥩 **Lunch:** Leftovers or 6oz canned sardines in olive oil
- 🥩 **Dinner:** 12oz lamb chops, pan-seared in butter + salt

Day 7 — Sunday *(Rest day — cook extra for the week)*

- 🍳 **Breakfast:** 4 eggs + 6 strips bacon + 1oz butter
- 🥩 **Lunch:** 8oz ground beef
- 🥩 **Dinner:** 2lb chuck roast slow-cooked in tallow (eat half, save half for Monday)

Week 2: The Fog Lifts

Day 8 — Monday

- 🍳 **Breakfast:** 4 eggs scrambled in butter + 4 strips bacon
- 🥩 **Lunch:** Leftover chuck roast, reheated (8oz portion)
- 🥩 **Dinner:** 12oz ribeye, seared hard in cast iron + butter

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Day 9 — Tuesday

- 🍳 **Breakfast:** 3 eggs + 3oz ground beef crumbles, cooked together in pan
- 🥩 **Lunch:** 8oz 80/20 ground beef patty + 2 slices cheddar (cheese optional)
- 🥩 **Dinner:** 10oz pork ribs (baby back), oven-roasted with salt and lard

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Day 10 — Wednesday

- 🍳 **Breakfast:** 4 fried eggs in butter + 4 strips bacon
- 🥩 **Lunch:** 6oz canned tuna mixed with a tablespoon of butter, warmed
- 🥩 **Dinner:** 10oz chicken thighs, skin-on, pan-fried in tallow until crispy

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Day 11 — Thursday

- 🍳 **Breakfast:** 4 eggs + 4 sausage patties (pork, no fillers)
- 🥩 **Lunch:** 8oz ground beef + mug of bone broth
- 🥩 **Dinner:** 12oz sirloin steak + 2 tbsp butter

Day 12 — Friday

- 🍳 **Breakfast:** Steak & eggs — 6oz ny strip + 3 eggs in butter
- 🥩 **Lunch:** 6oz smoked salmon + 2 soft-boiled eggs
- 🥩 **Dinner:** 10oz salmon fillet, pan-seared, finished with butter

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Day 13 — Saturday

- 🍳 **Breakfast:** 4 scrambled eggs + 6 strips bacon + coffee
- 🥩 **Lunch:** 8oz lamb burger patties, pan-fried
- 🥩 **Dinner:** 12oz ribeye + 1oz beef liver (try it — sauté in butter 90 seconds per side)

Day 14 — Sunday *(Two weeks in — you should be feeling the shift)*

- 🍳 **Breakfast:** 4 eggs + 4 strips bacon
- 🥩 **Lunch:** 8oz ground beef + mug of bone broth
- 🥩 **Dinner:** 2lb pork shoulder, oven-roasted in lard and salt (make extra)

Week 3: You're a Fat Burner Now

Day 15 — Monday

- 🍳 **Breakfast:** 4 eggs scrambled + 4 strips bacon
- 🥩 **Lunch:** Leftover pork shoulder (8oz)
- 🥩 **Dinner:** 12oz ribeye

Day 16 — Tuesday

- 🍳 **Breakfast:** 2 eggs + 6oz ground beef cooked together ("carnivore scramble")
- 🥩 **Lunch:** 6oz canned sardines or salmon + 2 boiled eggs
- 🥩 **Dinner:** 10oz chicken thighs skin-on + 2 tbsp butter

Day 17 — Wednesday

- 🍳 **Breakfast:** 4 eggs any style + 4 strips bacon
- 🥩 **Lunch:** 8oz 80/20 ground beef burger (no bun)
- 🥩 **Dinner:** 10oz pork chops, pan-seared in lard

Day 18 — Thursday

- 🍳 **Breakfast:** Steak & eggs — 8oz ground beef patty + 3 eggs
- 🥩 **Lunch:** 6oz smoked salmon + 2 hard-boiled eggs
- 🥩 **Dinner:** 12oz lamb chops, seared in butter

Day 19 — Friday

- 🍳 **Breakfast:** 4 fried eggs in butter + 6 strips bacon
- 🥩 **Lunch:** 8oz ground beef
- 🥩 **Dinner:** 12oz salmon fillet pan-seared in butter

Day 20 — Saturday

- 🍳 **Breakfast:** 4 scrambled eggs with 2oz cheddar (if using dairy) + 4 strips bacon
- 🥩 **Lunch:** 6oz canned tuna + 2 boiled eggs

- 🥩 **Dinner:** 12oz ribeye + 2oz beef liver (getting braver) + butter

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Day 21 — Sunday *(3 weeks — major milestone)*

- 🍳 **Breakfast:** 4 eggs + 4 strips bacon
- 🥩 **Lunch:** 8oz ground beef + bone broth
- 🥩 **Dinner:** 3lb beef short ribs, slow-roasted in oven (300°F, 3 hours)

Week 4: Dialed In

Day 22 — Monday

- 🍳 **Breakfast:** 4 eggs scrambled + 4 strips bacon
- 🥩 **Lunch:** Leftover short ribs (8oz)
- 🥩 **Dinner:** 12oz ribeye, reverse seared

Day 23 — Tuesday

- 🍳 **Breakfast:** 3 eggs + 6oz ground beef carnivore scramble
- 🥩 **Lunch:** 6oz smoked salmon + 2 boiled eggs
- 🥩 **Dinner:** 10oz skin-on chicken thighs, roasted crispy in tallow

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Day 24 — Wednesday

- 🍳 **Breakfast:** 4 fried eggs + 4 strips bacon
- 🥩 **Lunch:** 8oz ground beef burger patty
- 🥩 **Dinner:** 10oz pork shoulder, pan-roasted with salt and lard

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Day 25 — Thursday

- 🍳 **Breakfast:** Steak & eggs — 6oz sirloin + 3 eggs fried in the steak drippings
- 🥩 **Lunch:** 6oz canned sardines + 2 boiled eggs
- 🥩 **Dinner:** 12oz NY strip + 2 tbsp butter

Day 26 — Friday

- 🍳 **Breakfast:** 4 scrambled eggs + 6 strips bacon
- 🥩 **Lunch:** 8oz ground beef
- 🥩 **Dinner:** 12oz salmon fillet, skin-side down in cast iron, butter-basted

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Day 27 — Saturday

- 🍳 **Breakfast:** 4 eggs + 4oz ground beef scramble + coffee
- 🥩 **Lunch:** 8oz lamb burger patties
- 🥩 **Dinner:** 14oz ribeye (you earned it) + 2oz beef liver

Day 28 — Sunday *(Final week, going strong)*

- 🍳 **Breakfast:** 4 fried eggs in butter + 6 strips bacon
- 🥩 **Lunch:** 8oz ground beef + bone broth
- 🥩 **Dinner:** 2lb chuck roast, slow-cooked in oven 8 hours on 225°F

Day 29 — Monday

- 🍳 **Breakfast:** 4 eggs scrambled + 4 strips bacon
- 🥩 **Lunch:** Leftover chuck roast (8oz)
- 🥩 **Dinner:** 12oz ribeye

Day 30 — Tuesday 🎉 *CONGRATULATIONS — YOU DID IT*

- 🍳 **Breakfast:** Steak & eggs — your best ribeye + 4 eggs cooked in the fat
- 🥩 **Lunch:** 8oz ground beef + bone broth
- 🥩 **Dinner:** Whatever you want — as long as it had a mother or laid an egg. Celebrate.

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4. Weekly Shopping Lists {#shopping-lists}

> *Quantities assume **1 person** eating 2–3 meals per day at the portion sizes in the meal plan. Adjust accordingly.*

Week 1 Shopping List

Meat & Fish

- 80/20 ground beef — 3 lbs
- Ribeye steaks (at least 12oz each) — 2 steaks
- NY strip steak (12oz) — 1 steak
- Bacon (no sugar added) — 2 lbs
- Pork shoulder chops — 1.5 lbs
- Chicken thighs, skin-on, bone-in — 1.5 lbs
- Pork sausage links (no fillers/sugar) — 1 lb
- Canned wild salmon — 2 cans (6oz each)
- Lamb chops — 1 lb
- Chuck roast — 2 lbs
- Sirloin steak — 8oz

Eggs & Dairy

- Eggs — 3 dozen
- Butter (unsalted or salted) — 2 lbs
- Cheddar cheese (optional) — 4oz

Fats & Other

- Beef tallow — 1 jar (or render your own from beef fat)
- Lard (leaf lard preferred) — 1 jar
- Bone broth (high quality, no additives) — 1 quart
- Sea salt or Redmond Real Salt — 1 bag

Week 2 Shopping List

Meat & Fish

- 80/20 ground beef — 3 lbs
- Ribeye steaks — 2 steaks (12oz each)
- Baby back pork ribs — 1.5 lbs
- Bacon — 1.5 lbs
- Pork sausage patties (no fillers) — 1 lb

- Chicken thighs, skin-on — 1.5 lbs
- Salmon fillet — 1.5 lbs
- Smoked salmon — 4oz
- Canned tuna (in water or oil) — 2 cans
- Lamb burger patties (or ground lamb) — 1 lb
- Beef liver — 4oz (fresh, not frozen)
- Pork shoulder — 2 lbs
- Sirloin steak — 8oz

Eggs & Dairy

- Eggs — 2.5 dozen
- Butter — 1.5 lbs
- Cheddar cheese (optional) — 4oz

Other

- Bone broth — 1 quart
- Lard — replenish if needed

Week 3 Shopping List

Meat & Fish

- 80/20 ground beef — 3 lbs
- Ribeye steaks — 2 steaks
- Chicken thighs, skin-on — 1.5 lbs
- Pork chops — 1.5 lbs
- Bacon — 1.5 lbs
- Lamb chops — 1 lb
- Salmon fillet — 1.5 lbs
- Smoked salmon — 4oz
- Canned sardines — 2 cans
- Beef liver — 4oz
- Short ribs — 3 lbs
- Sirloin steak — 8oz

Eggs & Dairy

- Eggs — 2.5 dozen
- Butter — 1.5 lbs
- Cheddar (optional) — 4oz

Other

- Bone broth — 1 quart

Week 4 Shopping List

Meat & Fish

- 80/20 ground beef — 3 lbs
- Ribeye steaks — 3 steaks (including one good one for Day 30)
- NY strip steak — 1 steak
- Chicken thighs, skin-on — 1.5 lbs

- Pork shoulder — 2 lbs
- Bacon — 1.5 lbs
- Salmon fillet — 1.5 lbs
- Smoked salmon — 4oz
- Canned sardines — 2 cans
- Sirloin steak — 8oz
- Lamb burger patties — 1 lb
- Beef liver — 4oz
- Chuck roast — 2 lbs

Eggs & Dairy

- Eggs — 2.5 dozen
- Butter — 1.5 lbs

Other

- Bone broth — 1 quart

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5. Macro Tracking Guide {#macro-tracking}

Do You Need to Count Macros on Carnivore?

Short answer: **No.** Most people do fine eating until full and not tracking anything. The carnivore diet is naturally self-regulating because protein and fat are satiating.

However, if you're not losing weight, stalled, or want to optimize for performance or muscle building — knowing your macros is useful.

The Carnivore Macro Framework

Protein: 0.8–1.2g per pound of **lean body mass** (not total body weight)

- Example: 200lb person, 25% body fat → 150lb lean mass → target 120–180g protein/day
- Prioritize reaching your protein goal every day

Fat: Fill the rest of your calories with fat. Don't restrict fat — it's your fuel.

- Target: 60–80% of total calories from fat
- On 2,000 calories: 133–177g fat

Carbs: Zero. You're aiming for zero net carbs. The tiny amount in dairy (if you use it) is negligible.

Sample Macros for Different Goals

Goal	Calories	Protein	Fat
Weight loss (sedentary)	1,600–1,800	120–150g	100–130g
Maintenance	2,000–2,200	140–170g	130–160g
Muscle gain	2,400–2,800	180–220g	150–190g

Common Carnivore Foods & Their Macros

Food (4oz / ~113g)	Calories	Protein	Fat

80/20 ground beef	290	19g	23g
Ribeye steak	310	22g	24g
Bacon (3 strips ~30g)	130	9g	10g
Whole egg (1 large)	70	6g	5g
Butter (1 tbsp)	100	0g	11g
Salmon fillet	235	25g	14g
Chicken thigh (skin-on)	270	19g	20g
Pork belly	380	15g	35g
Beef liver	150	23g	4g

Practical Tracking Tips

1. **Use an app like Cronometer** — it has the most accurate meat database
2. **Weigh meat raw** — cooked weight varies based on fat/water loss
3. **Track for 3–5 days** to establish your baseline, then trust hunger signals
4. **If you're stalling:** Log for a week. Most people discover they're eating too many calories from dairy or eating too little protein.
5. **If you're losing too fast:** Add more fat. More butter, more fatty cuts, more bacon.

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6. Budget Carnivore vs. Premium {#budget-vs-premium}

Budget Carnivore: ~$100/week (1 person)

You can absolutely do carnivore on a tight budget. Here's how.

The Budget Stack:

- **80/20 ground beef** — Buy in bulk (5–10 lb packs). Often $4–6/lb. This is your protein cornerstone.
- **Eggs** — 2–3 dozen per week. ~$4–6/dozen. The cheapest protein per gram.
- **Chicken thighs (skin-on, bone-in)** — $1.50–2.50/lb. Cheap, fatty, delicious.
- **Bacon** — Buy store brand. $5–7/lb.
- **Canned sardines/mackerel** — $1.50–3/can. Cheap and loaded with omega-3s.
- **Canned tuna** — $1–2/can. Budget protein hit.
- **Pork shoulder** — $2–4/lb. Great slow-cooked.
- **Butter** — Store brand. ~$4–6/lb.
- **Lard** — Cheap cooking fat. $3–5/jar.

Sample $100/Week Basket:

- 10 lbs 80/20 ground beef: $50
- 3 dozen eggs: $15
- 2 lbs chicken thighs: $5
- 1 lb bacon: $6
- 4 cans sardines: $8
- 1 lb pork shoulder: $4
- 1 lb butter: $5
- Lard + salt: $7

- **Total: ~$100**

Budget Carnivore Tips:

- Shop Costco, Walmart, or Aldi for bulk meat
- Buy whole chickens and break them down yourself
- Look for manager specials (near-expiration meat, freeze it)
- Organ meats (liver, heart) are dirt cheap and incredibly nutrient-dense — $1–3/lb
- Learn to render your own fat from beef trimmings (free from the butcher)

Premium Carnivore: ~$200/week (1 person)

When you can spend more, upgrade your meat quality and variety.

The Premium Stack:

- **Grass-fed/finished ribeyes and NY strips** — $15–25/lb. Better fatty acid profile.
- **Wild-caught salmon** — Fresh, not farmed. $15–20/lb.
- **Pastured eggs** — $6–10/dozen. Better yolks, more omega-3.
- **Grass-fed butter (Kerrygold)** — $6–8/lb.
- **Wagyu ground beef** — Rich, buttery, incredibly satiating.
- **Lamb chops** — $12–20/lb. Great flavor, grass-fed by default.
- **Bone broth (high quality)** — $8–15/quart vs. making your own.
- **Smoked salmon** — Wild-caught. $10–15 for 4oz.
- **Beef liver (grass-fed)** — $4–8/lb.

Sample $200/Week Basket:

- 3 lbs grass-fed ribeye: $60
- 2 lbs wild-caught salmon: $36
- 3 dozen pastured eggs: $24
- 2 lbs grass-fed ground beef: $14
- 2 lbs bacon (sugar-free, nitrate-free): $16
- 1 lb lamb chops: $16
- 2 lbs Kerrygold butter: $12
- Bone broth (2 quarts): $20
- **Total: ~$200**

Is Grass-Fed Worth It?

Nutritionally, yes — grass-fed beef has a better omega-6 to omega-3 ratio and more CLA (conjugated linoleic acid). But conventionally raised beef is still excellent food. Don't let perfect be the enemy of good. Budget carnivore is still 10x better than the standard American diet.

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7. Eating Out Guide {#eating-out}

The Good News

Eating carnivore at restaurants is easier than you think. Every restaurant has protein. You just have to order strategically and not be afraid to make substitutions.

What to Order at Common Restaurants

Steakhouse (Easy Mode)

- Any steak — ribeye, NY strip, filet, T-bone
- Ask for butter on top
- Skip the sides or ask for extra steak instead
- Eggs Benedict: eat the eggs and Canadian bacon, leave the English muffin
- "Just bring me the steak and some extra butter"

Burger Joint

- Any burger, no bun, no sauce
- Double the patty
- Skip the fries
- Add bacon and cheese if you do dairy
- In-N-Out Protein Style = no bun, lettuce wrap (skip the lettuce on strict carnivore)

BBQ

- Brisket, ribs, pulled pork — all good
- Skip the sides (coleslaw, beans, corn)
- Sauces often have sugar — ask for unsauced or ask to see the ingredients
- "Can I get extra meat instead of sides?"

Mexican Restaurant

- Fajita meat (chicken, steak, shrimp) with no tortillas
- Skip all the sides (rice, beans, chips, guac)
- Grilled chicken or steak, plain
- Carnitas (usually just pork, lard, salt — great)

Breakfast/Diner

- Eggs any style
- Bacon or sausage (check for added sugars/fillers)
- Ask to sub any carb sides for extra eggs or meat
- "2 eggs, bacon, and can I get an extra side of bacon instead of the toast?"

Fast Food (Emergency Use)

- McDonald's: bunless burger, extra patty, skip the sauce
- Chipotle: steak or chicken bowl, no rice/beans/salsa, add sour cream/cheese
- Subway: tuna or chicken on a salad (no croutons, no dressing)
- Chick-fil-A: grilled chicken strips, plain

Eating Out Rules

1. **Don't be embarrassed to make substitutions.** Say: "I'm on a strict medical elimination diet." Servers and kitchens are used to accommodations.
2. **Ask how things are cooked.** Seed oils (soybean oil, canola) are common. Ask if they can cook in butter.
3. **Skip all sauces.** They're all loaded with sugar, seed oils, or both.
4. **Stick to simple.** Grilled > fried (breading). Plain > sauced.
5. **Eat before you go** if you're unsure about the menu. Show up not starving and order strategically.
6. **Don't be dogmatic.** If you're traveling and the only option is a fast-food burger, eat the burger, skip the bun, and move on. Perfection is the enemy of progress.

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8. Electrolytes & Supplements {#electrolytes}

Why Electrolytes Matter on Carnivore

When you cut carbohydrates, insulin levels drop. Low insulin signals your kidneys to excrete sodium. As sodium exits, it takes potassium and magnesium with it. This electrolyte loss is the #1 cause of:

- Headaches
- Muscle cramps
- Fatigue
- Heart palpitations
- Brain fog

The fix is simple: **replace what you're losing.**

The Big Three

🧂 Sodium

How much: 3,000–5,000mg per day (most people on carnivore need more than this general recommendation) **Sources:**

- Salt your food generously — all of it
- Drink salted water (1/4 tsp salt in 8oz water) in the morning
- Bone broth (naturally sodium-rich)
- Bacon and cured meats

Salt to use: Redmond Real Salt, Celtic Sea Salt, or Himalayan Pink Salt. All contain trace minerals. Avoid plain iodized table salt (though it works in a pinch).

💊 Magnesium

How much: 300–500mg per day **Best form:** Magnesium glycinate or magnesium malate. Avoid magnesium oxide (poorly absorbed, causes diarrhea). **When to take:** Before bed — it improves sleep and reduces nighttime cramps. **Signs you need more:** Muscle cramps, poor sleep, constipation, anxiety.

Food sources of magnesium on carnivore:

- Beef (some)
- Salmon (some)
- Sardines (decent)
- Bone broth (trace amounts)

You almost certainly need to supplement magnesium on carnivore.

🍌 Potassium

How much: 2,000–3,500mg per day **Sources (carnivore-friendly):**

- Beef (ground beef has ~300mg per 4oz)
- Salmon (~500mg per 4oz) — best carnivore source
- Chicken (~250mg per 4oz)
- Bacon (small amount)

Supplement options: Potassium chloride (NoSalt or NuSalt brand) — dissolve in water. Potassium supplements are limited to 99mg/pill by FDA, so food sources matter more.

Don't over-supplement potassium — too much is dangerous. Get it from food first, supplement cautiously.

Simple Electrolyte Protocol

Morning: Glass of water with 1/4 tsp Redmond salt + a squeeze of lemon (optional) **With meals:** Salt food generously **Evening:** 300–400mg magnesium glycinate **Throughout day:** Eat sodium-rich foods (bacon, salted butter, bone broth)

Electrolyte Drink Recipe

Mix in 16oz water:

- 1/4 tsp sea salt (~600mg sodium)
- 1/8 tsp NoSalt or NuSalt (~650mg potassium)
- Optional: squeeze of lemon or a few drops of Liquid IV for flavor

This costs pennies and works better than most electrolyte products.

Should You Supplement Anything Else?

Vitamin D3 + K2: Recommended if you don't get much sun. 5,000 IU D3 + 100mcg K2 daily.

B12: Abundant in meat, especially liver. If you eat liver weekly, you don't need to supplement.

Fish oil/Omega-3: If you eat salmon and sardines 3+ times per week, skip it. If you're beef-heavy, consider 2g EPA/DHA daily.

What you DON'T need:

- Multivitamins (you're eating the most nutrient-dense food on earth)
- Vitamin C (contrary to popular belief, carnivores rarely develop scurvy — fresh meat contains some C and the need drops dramatically without glucose competition)
- Fiber supplements (your gut will adapt)
- Digestive enzymes (your body will ramp up bile production naturally)

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9. Top 10 Beginner Mistakes {#common-mistakes}

Mistake #1: Not Eating Enough Fat

This is the #1 mistake. People come from a low-fat mindset and instinctively lean toward chicken breast and lean ground beef. On carnivore, fat is your fuel. If you under-eat fat, you'll be hungry, tired, and miserable. Choose fatty cuts: ribeye over sirloin, 80/20 over 93/7, chicken thighs over breast, pork belly over loin.

Fix: If you're hungry an hour after eating, add more fat to your meal.

Mistake #2: Under-Salting

The standard dietary advice to avoid salt is wrong for carnivore. When carbs are cut, your kidneys dump sodium. Most carnivore symptoms (headache, fatigue, cramps, brain fog) are sodium deficiency. Salt your food generously. You cannot over-salt on carnivore as easily as you might think.

Fix: Salt every meal. Drink salted water in the morning. Eat more bacon.

Mistake #3: Quitting During Adaptation

Most people who "tried carnivore and it didn't work" quit in days 2–5 — the hardest stretch. Adaptation symptoms are real but temporary. If you quit now, you reset your adaptation timer and have to go through it

again.

Fix: Commit to 30 days minimum. Day 6–7 almost always brings relief. Day 14 is a different world.

Mistake #4: Eating Processed Meats With Fillers

Most sausages, hot dogs, and deli meats contain wheat flour, dextrose (sugar), corn syrup, or other fillers. These will kick you out of adaptation and may cause gut issues.

Fix: Read labels. Ingredients should be: meat, salt, spices. That's it. Look for brands like Epic, Pederson's, or US Wellness Meats.

Mistake #5: Using Seed Oils for Cooking

Canola oil, vegetable oil, soybean oil, sunflower oil — these are inflammatory and should not be part of a carnivore lifestyle. They oxidize at cooking temperatures and damage cells.

Fix: Cook only in butter, ghee, tallow, lard, or duck fat. These are stable animal fats that are perfect for high-heat cooking.

Mistake #6: Overdoing Dairy Early

Heavy cream, cheese, and butter are borderline carnivore. Many people tolerate them fine, but dairy contains lactose (a sugar) and can be inflammatory for some people. If you're not losing weight or feel bloated, dairy is the first thing to cut.

Fix: For the first 30 days, limit dairy to butter and hard aged cheeses (which have minimal lactose). Remove dairy entirely if progress stalls.

Mistake #7: Expecting Immediate Weight Loss

The scale will drop 5–10 lbs in week 1 from water weight. Then it may stall or even tick up as inflammation resolves and muscles retain water more efficiently. This freaks people out.

Fix: Don't weigh yourself every day. Take measurements and photos instead. The mirror is a better judge than the scale on carnivore.

Mistake #8: Not Drinking Enough Water

Carbohydrates hold water in your body. When you cut carbs, you lose water rapidly. Many adaptation symptoms are actually mild dehydration.

Fix: Drink when thirsty. Aim for at least 64oz of water per day. More if you're active or it's hot. Add electrolytes — plain water alone won't rehydrate you as efficiently.

Mistake #9: Eating Lean Proteins at Every Meal

Chicken breast, tuna, egg whites — these are fine protein sources, but eating only lean protein without fat will make you feel terrible (rabbit starvation, clinically called "protein poisoning"). Your body can't run on protein alone — it needs fat for fuel.

Fix: Pair every lean protein with added fat. Chicken breast + butter. Tuna + mayo (homemade with avocado oil). Never eat lean protein without fat.

Mistake #10: Skipping Organ Meats

Liver and other organ meats are the most nutrient-dense foods on the planet. 4oz of beef liver has more vitamin A than any plant food, more B12 than almost anything, and a complete amino acid profile. People avoid liver because of taste — but cooked right, it's good.

Fix: Start with 2oz of liver twice a week, cooked in butter with onions (wait — no onions on carnivore). Sear it hot, 90 seconds per side, slightly pink inside. Or blend it raw into ground beef (1:8 ratio) — you won't taste it.

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10. FAQ: Top 20 Questions {#faq}

Q1: Can I have coffee? Technically coffee is not carnivore (it comes from a plant). However, most carnivore practitioners allow black coffee because the adaptation benefits of carnivore don't seem to be meaningfully disrupted by black coffee. If you're strict: no. If you're practical: yes, black coffee only. No sugar, no creamers, no flavored syrups.

Q2: Can I drink alcohol? Hard pass for 30 days. Alcohol disrupts fat burning, disrupts sleep, has empty calories, and makes adaptation harder. After 30 days, if you choose to drink, straight spirits (vodka, whiskey, gin) are lower carb than beer or wine. But honestly — most people lose interest in alcohol on carnivore because they just feel too good sober.

Q3: Will I get scurvy without vitamin C? This fear is based on old data from high-carb populations. Fresh, unprocessed meat contains small amounts of vitamin C. More importantly, when you remove carbohydrates, glucose no longer competes with vitamin C for cellular uptake — so your body needs far less of it. Carnivores have been studied without supplementation and show no signs of vitamin deficiency.

Q4: Is it safe for my kidneys? Healthy kidneys handle high protein just fine. The "high protein damages kidneys" myth applies only to people with pre-existing kidney disease. If you have a kidney condition, consult your doctor. For everyone else, studies show no kidney damage from high protein intake in healthy people.

Q5: My cholesterol went up. Should I be worried? Possibly not. On carnivore, many people see LDL increase but also HDL increase and triglycerides drop dramatically. The ratio matters more than LDL alone. More importantly, LDL particle size often shifts to large, fluffy particles (benign) rather than small, dense particles (problematic). Request an NMR lipid panel or advanced cholesterol test, not a basic lipid panel.

Q6: How much should I eat? Eat until satisfied. Don't count calories initially. Most people naturally eat 1,600–2,500 calories per day on carnivore without trying. If you're losing weight too fast, eat more fat. If you're not losing weight, try reducing dairy and tracking for a few days.

Q7: Can I eat as much as I want? Yes and no. Eating to satiety is the goal. You'll find it nearly impossible to overeat on carnivore because protein and fat suppress appetite powerfully. But if you're eating around the clock and gaining weight, something is off — usually too much dairy or eating out of boredom.

Q8: How often should I eat? Most carnivores naturally settle into 1–2 meals per day (OMAD or two meals). This happens on its own — you just stop getting hungry. Don't force meal timing; let your appetite guide you. During adaptation, eat 3 meals if you need to.

Q9: What if I'm constipated? Very common in the first 1–3 weeks. Your gut is adjusting. Drink more water, salt more, and eat more fat. Magnesium citrate (500mg) can help as a short-term fix. Most people find they need far less bathroom time on carnivore once adapted — this is normal.

Q10: What if I have diarrhea? Also common in week 1. Your gut is shifting bacteria, your bile production is increasing, and your intestines are adjusting. It usually resolves by week 2. If it persists: reduce fat temporarily, then slowly increase it. Digestive bitters can help your body adapt to higher fat intake.

Q11: Can I do carnivore while breastfeeding or pregnant? Meat, eggs, and animal fat are excellent pregnancy foods — nutrient-dense and complete. However, strict carnivore during pregnancy or breastfeeding should be done under medical supervision. A modified carnivore diet with some well-tolerated plants is more commonly recommended.

Q12: Will I lose muscle? No — if you eat enough protein. In fact, many people gain muscle on carnivore due to the abundance of complete amino acids, improved sleep and recovery, and reduced inflammation. Eat 1g protein per pound of lean body mass and lift weights. You will not lose muscle.

Q13: What about fiber? Don't I need it for gut health? The "fiber is essential" claim is not supported by the evidence many people believe it is. Many people find their gut health dramatically improves on zero-fiber carnivore because the fermentable fibers that feed problematic gut bacteria are removed. Give your gut 60–90 days to adapt before drawing conclusions.

Q14: Can I do intermittent fasting with carnivore? Yes, and it works extremely well together. Most carnivores naturally fall into a 16:8 or OMAD pattern. Don't force it in week 1 — eat enough to get through adaptation. After 2–3 weeks, try skipping breakfast and eating your first meal at noon.

Q15: What's the best cut of beef? For taste and fat: **ribeye**. For budget: **80/20 ground beef**. For nutrition: **liver**. Honestly, if you ate nothing but ground beef, eggs, and butter for 30 days, you'd be just fine.

Q16: I'm not losing weight. What's wrong? Common culprits:

1. Too much dairy (cheese and cream add up fast)
2. Eating too frequently — try 2 meals/day
3. Too many processed carnivore foods
4. Stress and poor sleep (cortisol kills fat loss)
5. Not eating enough fat earlier, causing overeating later

Track your food for 3–5 days and see what's actually happening.

Q17: Can I eat hot sauce or spices? Strict carnivore = salt only. Practical carnivore = most people use salt, black pepper, and occasionally garlic powder. Hot sauce has small amounts of plant ingredients. If you're doing a strict elimination protocol for autoimmune reasons, use only salt. For general health and weight loss, a little black pepper or cayenne is not going to derail you.

Q18: How long until I see results?

- **Weight loss:** 1–3 weeks (most see changes in week 2 after water weight settles)
- **Energy:** Days 5–10
- **Mental clarity:** Days 7–14
- **Skin improvements:** 3–6 weeks
- **Autoimmune improvement:** 60–90 days

- **Fully fat-adapted:** 4–8 weeks

Q19: Do I need to rotate proteins or can I eat beef every day? Eat whatever you enjoy. Beef every day is completely safe and actually common among dedicated carnivores. Beef, eggs, and butter is a complete nutritional profile. Variety is fine but not required.

Q20: What happens after 30 days? You have options:

1. **Continue carnivore** — most people do. They feel too good to stop.
2. **Slow reintroduction** — add back low-toxin plants one at a time (white rice, well-cooked squash) to see what you tolerate.
3. **Modified carnivore/ketovore** — mostly animal products with some low-carb plants.

Before you reintroduce anything, ask yourself: How do I feel right now? If the answer is great — why change?

Final Words

You made it through 30 days of carnivore. That's not nothing.

You swam upstream against decades of dietary dogma that told you fat would kill you, red meat would give you cancer, and vegetables were non-negotiable. You did it anyway.

What you discovered — in your own body, not on paper — is more valuable than any study. You now know how you feel running on meat and fat. You know what it's like to wake up without brain fog, to eat a meal and not think about food for 5 hours, to lose weight without counting a calorie.

That knowledge is yours forever.

What you do with it is up to you. But you now have a baseline for what "feeling good" actually means.

Keep it simple. Eat meat. Salt your food. Drink water.

The rest takes care of itself.

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